Classic Story Structures & Techniques (Made Simple)

Now that we have the basic ingredients, how do we put them together effectively? Storytellers over time have developed **frameworks** – sort of tried-and-true shapes that stories often follow. You don't have to rigidly stick to a formula, but knowing these can help you structure your 60-second story in a way that feels natural and compelling.

The Three-Act Structure (Beginning, Middle, End): This is a classic for a reason – it's basically how we naturally tell stories.

- **Act 1 – Beginning:** Introduce the situation and character. (*Setup*)
- **Act 2 – Middle:** Present a conflict or challenge. Things get interesting! (*Confrontation*)
- **Act 3 – End:** Resolve the conflict or show the outcome. (*Resolution*)

Even in a one-minute video, you can use this three-part flow. For example, in the first ~10 seconds you set the scene, by ~30 second mark you show the conflict escalating, and in the final 10-20 seconds you deliver the payoff. Keeping this **"beginning-middle-end"** mindset ensures your story has a clear arcstoryleague.com.austoryleague.com.au. Viewers subconsciously expect a setup, a problem, and a resolution – if any part is missing, the story might feel incomplete.

The "Hero's Journey" (in brief): The Hero's Journey is a more detailed mythical structure (with stages like Call to Adventure, Crisis, Return, etc.), famously described by Joseph Campbell. In short videos, you obviously can't cover all those stages, but you can tap into the idea of a **transformation**. Essentially: a character starts in one place, faces something, and ends up changed. For instance, in one minute, you can show a "before" and "after" of a character thanks to an experience. This is great for relatable or inspirational content (like someone overcoming a fear or trying something new quickly). The Hero's Journey framework is popular because audiences immediately recognize that archetype of growthstoryleague.com.au – even if it's very simplified for a short story.

The South Park "But/Therefore" Technique: This is a golden rule for keeping any story engaging, credited to Trey Parker and Matt Stone (creators of *South Park*). The idea is simple: **Avoid telling a "and then, and then" story.** Instead, connect your story beats with **"but…"** or **"therefore…"**perell.comperell.com.

- "And then" just lists events: *This happened, and then that happened, and then another thing happened.* That often feels dull or randomperell.com.
- Using "but" and "therefore" introduces *cause and effect* and *conflict*: *This happened,* ***but*** *then [obstacle] happened,* ***therefore*** *the character did X.* This makes the story automatically more interestingperell.com.

For example, instead of saying: "I started filming a vlog, **and then** my phone rang, **and then** I went outside," you'd introduce a "but" or "therefore": "I started filming a vlog, **but** my phone rang with an emergency call. **Therefore,** I rushed outside to see what happened." Suddenly there's tension and a reason one event leads to the next. In any short story, try to apply this rule at least once: find a spot where you can replace an "and then" with a "but" (to introduce a twist/obstacle) and a "therefore" (to show the consequence). This creates a mini narrative arc that keeps viewers hooked through the middle of your video.

Other Quick Frameworks and Tips:

- **Once upon a time…**: A very short formula inspired by Pixar's storytelling exercise is: "*Once upon a time there was ___. Every day, ___. One day ___. Because of that, ___. Because of that, ___. Until finally ___.*" This classic fill-in-the-blank story can be a fun way to outline your script. You probably won't say "once upon a time" in a TikTok, but the idea of setting a scene, then a *big event*, then consequences, and finally an outcome, is useful. You can try writing your story in one or two sentences using this formula as a test to ensure it flows.

- **Start at the end (flashback):** One clever technique for short videos is to **show the result or climax first**, then rewind to explain. For example, your opening shot might be something wild or attention-grabbing from the end of the story – "**Here's me on top of a mountain, crying with joy.**" Then the video goes into how you got there: "30 minutes earlier, I was terrified to even start the hike…" This "result-first, then backtrack" method hooks viewers with the payoff up front, then keeps them watching to see the story behind it. It's like starting a story at the most exciting part, then saying "Now let me tell you how we got here." This framework (sometimes called **"Results-first"** or **reverse narrative**) works great to immediately intrigue your audience.

- **The Elevator Pitch:** Especially useful for personal or brand stories – imagine you have to describe your story in the length of an elevator ride (very short). Focus on the key point and why it matters. In an elevator-pitch style story, you quickly answer: *Who are you? What happened? Why should the viewer care?* This helps to keep your story **concise** and clear.

Remember, these frameworks are tools, not strict rules. You might mix and match them. For instance, you can use a 3-Act structure *and* apply the "But/Therefore" technique within it. Or start with a flashback hook and then do a quick beginning-middle-end. The goal is simply to give your one-minute story a **strong backbone**. A tiny story can feel as satisfying as a longer one if it's structured well.